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THE INDIAN PILOT CAREER PLAYBOOK 2026-27

CPL, cadet programmes and your first airline job

40 sections - 16 tables - one 24-month plan
Every rule, fee and deadline verified against DGCA, PIB and Ministry of Civil Aviation sources, October 2026

INSIDE

What a licence is and is not - the real cost - the four routes - medicals
Five DGCA papers and the 2026 calendar - RTR(A) after the takeover - 200 hours
The April 2026 FTO ranking - DGCA's October 2026 contract rules - pay - loans

Educational material. Verify current rules at dgca.gov.in before you commit money.

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How to use this playbook

This is a working document, not a motivational one. It assumes you are seriously considering spending between Rs 55 lakh and Rs 1 crore of your family's money on a career, and that you would rather know the awkward parts now.

Read Part One and Part Two before you pay anyone anything. Those two parts are designed to be read in an evening and they will either strengthen your decision or save you the cost of it. Part Three and Part Four are the licensing and training manual you will keep coming back to. Part Five is about getting hired. Part Six is the money. Part Seven is the calendar, the checklists and the answers, and it is the part most people will print.

Every regulatory statement, fee and deadline was checked against a primary source in October 2026 - DGCA's Civil Aviation Requirements and circulars, the Ministry of Civil Aviation, PIB releases, parliamentary replies, airline career pages and bank scheme documents. Where a number is a market estimate rather than an official figure, the text says so. Section 40 lists every source so you can re-verify anything that matters before you commit money.

What changed in 2026-27

Four things have changed in the last eighteen months that make older advice actively misleading. If you have been reading forums from 2023, start here.

Table A. The changes that matter most

Change	What it means for you
Flying schools are now ranked by DGCA, twice a year	The second ranking was published on 24 April 2026 covering 35 schools. Use it before you shortlist, and check the category again on the day you pay.
DGCA took over the RTR(A) examination from WPC	From 1 December 2025 the radio licence is examined and issued by DGCA. Old WPC licences issued or renewed up to 15 July 2026 are accepted; study material from before that date is often out of date.
New contract rules for flying schools, from 5 October 2026	Fees in four progressive 25 per cent blocks, no blanket non-refundable clause, refunds ordinarily in 15 working days, records released on transfer. This is the most useful protection a trainee has ever had.
Pilot licences are digital	The Electronic Personnel Licence has applied to CPLs since February 2025, to renewals since June 2025, and to ATPLs since January 2026. It lives in the eGCA app, works offline after one login, and can be registered on two devices.
The Physics and Maths rule may be about to change	Draft rules published in July 2025 would allow a CPL after 10+2 without Physics and Mathematics. As of 16 October 2026 they had administrative approval but were not published. Plan on the current rule.
Training capacity is expanding	41 flying schools across 63 bases with over 400 aircraft by mid-2026, and 11 new school slots tendered at AAI airports. More seats, but still far short of the 30,000 pilots the Ministry says India needs.

The 60-second answer

- You need: 18 years, 10+2 with Physics and Mathematics (NIOS is accepted), a Class 2 then a Class 1 medical, five DGCA papers at 70 per cent each, an RTR(A) licence, 200 hours of flying with specific sub-requirements, and four flight tests.
- It costs: Rs 55 lakh to Rs 1 crore all-in, with the type rating as the difference between the two ends.
- It takes: two and a half to four years to a CPL, plus two to four months for a type rating, plus a variable wait for a seat.
- Do this first: the Ishihara colour vision check, then the Class 1 medical. Before any deposit.

- Do this second: the Computer Number, then shortlist schools from DGCA's April 2026 ranking.
- Never do this: pay a school in full, sign an agreement without the four 25 per cent blocks, or accept a 'guaranteed job'.

PART ONE

The Decision

Everything here happens before you pay a flying school a single rupee. Read it twice, because this is the part that decides whether the next three years of your life and your family's savings make sense.

1 What you are actually buying

A Commercial Pilot Licence is a permit to be paid for flying. It is not a job offer, and it is not a guarantee of one. Almost every disappointment in Indian pilot training starts with those two sentences being confused.

The licence itself is a regulatory bundle, not a single qualification. To hold a CPL for aeroplanes under Section J of Schedule II of the Aircraft Rules, 1937, you must separately satisfy the regulator on age, education, medical fitness, five written examinations, a radio telephony licence, 200 hours of logged flight time with specific sub-requirements, and a set of flight tests within six months of applying. Fail any one and the licence is not issued, no matter how much you have spent.

Then there is a second layer that DGCA does not control at all. An airline flies Airbus A320s and Boeing 737s. Your CPL will have been earned on a Cessna 172 or a Piper Archer. To sit in the right-hand seat of a jet you need a type rating on that jet, which is a separate course, a separate fee, and - in India - very often self-funded. A CPL gets you into the queue. A CPL plus a type rating plus a clean medical plus an airline that happens to be hiring gets you a job.

This guide treats those as three distinct problems, because they are. Part Two and Three get you licensed. Part Four gets you trained without losing money. Part Five gets you hired. Part Six is the money, and Part Seven is the calendar and the checklists you will actually use.

The one-line summary

Budget Rs 55 lakh to Rs 1 crore all-in. Plan on three years, not eighteen months. Clear your Class 1 medical before you pay any deposit. Pick your flying school on the DGCA ranking and a signed contract, not on a brochure.

2 The market: 30,000 pilots wanted, 1,331 licences issued

India genuinely needs pilots. The gap between what the country needs and what its training system produces is the reason this career is worth considering - and the reason it is crowded at the entry point.

In a written reply in the Rajya Sabha on 2 February 2026, the Ministry of Civil Aviation stated that 6,648 commercial pilot licences were issued in the previous five years, and that the present overall pilot-to-aircraft ratio across Indian airlines is 8.4. It also stated that since 2016 roughly 40 per cent of CPLs have gone to cadets trained at foreign institutes.

On demand, the Ministry has put the requirement at close to 30,000 additional pilots over the next decade - a figure repeated by the Civil Aviation Minister at the release of the second FTO ranking in April 2026, and by the Airports Authority of India in its 2026 tender documents, which put the estimate at 30,000 to 31,800.

Now the supply side, which is where the story gets more useful. In February 2026 the government told the Lok Sabha that India had 25,001 pilots under the age of 65 holding valid licences: 10,051 ATPL holders for aeroplanes, 210 for helicopters, 12,480 CPL holders for aeroplanes, 777 for helicopters, and 1,483 private

pilots. Annual CPL issuance was 1,347 in 2024 and 1,652 in 2025. By 30 June 2026, 1,331 CPLs had already been issued that year, of which 791 came from Indian flying schools and 540 from foreign ones.

Read those numbers together and the shape of the opportunity appears. Roughly 1,300 to 1,650 new commercial licences a year, against a requirement that implies something in the region of 3,000 a year for a decade. The bottleneck is not demand. It is training capacity: as on 22 January 2026 there were 40 DGCA-approved flying training organisations with 385 trainer aircraft, and the regulator's own instructor-to-aircraft-to-student ratio of 1:1:10 caps them at roughly 3,500 trainees at any one time.

That capacity is being expanded. By mid-2026 the count had reached 41 FTOs across 63 bases with over 400 aircraft, and in August 2026 the AAI completed tenders for 11 new FTO slots at seven of its airports. For you, the practical consequence is this: a seat in a good school is scarce, aircraft availability decides your timeline far more than your talent does, and a school that cannot get you into the air is the single biggest risk to your money.

3 The real cost: Rs 45 lakh to Rs 1 crore

Nobody in Indian pilot training quotes you the whole number, because the whole number is assembled from four separate purchases made months or years apart.

The first purchase is ground school and the DGCA examinations - modest, a few lakh at most. The second is flight training to 200 hours, which is 70 to 80 per cent of the bill. The third is the multi-engine and instrument training that a jet job expects. The fourth, which most brochures omit entirely, is the type rating.

Table 1. The four purchases, and what each one typically costs in 2026

Stage	What it buys	Indicative cost
Ground school and DGCA papers	Coaching for five theory papers, exam fees, books	Rs 0.5 - 2 lakh plus exam fees
Flight training to CPL (200 hours)	The flying itself: single-engine hours, cross-country, night, instrument, skill tests	Rs 30 - 64 lakh depending on school tier
Multi-engine and instrument rating	The endorsements a jet job expects; frequently quoted separately from 'CPL'	Rs 3 - 8 lakh
Type rating (A320 or B737)	The rating that lets you fly an airliner at all	Rs 15 - 30 lakh, or bundled into a cadet programme

Add the invisible lines and the range widens further: living costs near an airfield for 18 to 24 months, medicals, uniform, headset, landing and parking charges, and the extra flying hours that weather and re-tests quietly add. A realistic all-in figure for a self-sponsored candidate today is Rs 55 lakh to Rs 1 crore, with the type rating being the difference between the two ends.

One official anchor is worth having, because it is a published number rather than a market rumour. Indira Gandhi Rashtriya Uran Akademi, the Ministry of Civil Aviation's own flying academy, advertised its ab-initio CPL course for the 2026 intake at a training fee of Rs 55,00,000, with an admission fee of Rs 50,000, a commitment deposit of Rs 2,00,000 adjustable against the fee, hostel and messing at about Rs 15,000 a month, and optional type rating at Rs 17,00,000 for A320 or B737 and Rs 19,00,000 for ATR-72 or Q400. The application fee was Rs 15,000. That is a government institution quoting you the honest version.

> *Every figure in this guide is a 2026 figure, and every one of them will move. Fees track aviation fuel prices, aircraft availability and the rupee. Treat them as the shape of the bill, and get a written quote before you commit.*

4 The four routes, compared honestly

There are four ways to end up in an airline cockpit from India. They differ less in the licence you end up with than in who carries the risk.

Table 2. The four routes

Route	How it works	Cost and time	The catch
Indian FTO, self-sponsored	You join a DGCA-approved flying school, clear papers and 200 hours, then buy a type rating	Rs 45 - 90 lakh plus rating; 2.5 - 4 years	You carry all the risk. No job at the end unless an airline is hiring
Airline cadet programme	Airline selects you, trains you, type-rates you, then employs you as a trainee pilot	Rs 90 lakh - 1.2 crore, often loan-funded; about 24 months	Expensive, competitive, and typically bonded. An offer is not an unconditional guarantee
Training abroad, then conversion	Fly at a foreign school, convert the licence to a DGCA CPL	Rs 65 - 85 lakh; add 4 - 6 months for conversion	Conversion exams and flying, visa risk, and DGCA cannot help you with a foreign school's refunds
Indian Air Force	Fly for the air force, then transition to civil aviation on retirement or release	Free, and you are paid	A different career with its own selection and a long commitment. Not a shortcut

Most people reading this will take route one. Route two is the fastest and the most expensive, and it is worth understanding exactly what the airline is promising - Part Five covers that in detail. Route three has become less attractive as Indian capacity has expanded; the Ministry's own data shows the domestic share of new CPLs rising, with 791 of the 1,331 licences issued in the first half of 2026 coming from Indian schools.

Route four deserves a note because it is often misunderstood. An IAF career is not a cheap way to a CPL. It is a career in its own right, with its own medical standards, its own commitment, and a transition to civil flying that happens on the Air Force's timeline, not yours.

5 The honest self-check

Twelve questions. If you cannot answer eight of them with a clear yes, the most valuable thing this guide can do for you is save you Rs 60 lakh.

1. Can you pass a colour vision test? Not 'I think so' - have you actually been tested?
2. Can your family fund Rs 55 lakh to Rs 90 lakh, or secure collateral for a loan of that size?
3. Are you willing to be a student again for three years, in a small town, on a roster decided by weather?
4. Do you have Physics and Mathematics at 10+2 level, or are you willing to take them through NIOS?
5. Are you at least 18, and realistically under 32 if you want a cadet programme?
6. Can you sit five technical examinations in English and pass each at 70 per cent?
7. Do you understand that a CPL is not a job offer?
8. Can you absorb a 12 to 18 month delay without the plan collapsing financially?
9. Are you comfortable being assessed on aptitude, coordination and personality, not just marks?
10. Do you have a plan B if you are declared temporarily unfit at a medical review?
11. Is someone in your family able to co-sign a loan and pledge collateral if required?
12. Would you still want this if the first airline job paid Rs 1 lakh a month for two years?

The failure modes are consistent enough to name. The most expensive is paying a school deposit before discovering a medical problem - a Class 1 medical costs a few thousand rupees and can end the entire plan, so it belongs at the very start. The second is budgeting for the CPL and forgetting the type rating. The third is choosing a school on a brochure and a fee, and discovering in month nine that only two of its aircraft are serviceable. The fourth is treating an eighteen-month completion estimate as a commitment; the DGCA's own ranking framework exists partly because completion times across Indian schools vary enormously.

PART TWO

Eligibility and Medicals

The cheapest part of the journey, and the part that ends it for more people than any examination does. Do this first, in this order, before you sign anything.

6 Eligibility: age, marks, and the Physics problem

DGCA's requirements are narrower than a flying school's, and it helps to know which is which. A school's admission filter is a commercial policy. DGCA's is law.

Under Section J of Schedule II of the Aircraft Rules, 1937, an applicant for a Commercial Pilot Licence (Aeroplanes) must be not less than eighteen years of age on the date of application, and must have passed Class 10+2 or an equivalent examination with Physics and Mathematics from a recognised board or university. DGCA's Pariksha portal FAQ says the same thing: applicants other than the PPL category must have passed 10+2 with Physics and Mathematics.

Notice what is not there: a minimum percentage. DGCA specifies a pass, not a mark. Flying schools routinely ask for 50 or 51 per cent, and airline cadet programmes ask for 51 or 60 per cent with individual subject minimums - those are real requirements for those routes, but they are not DGCA's eligibility rule. A rejection by one school on marks is not a rejection by the profession.

If you took Commerce, Arts or Biology

You are not disqualified. You need Physics and Mathematics at 10+2 level through an accepted route, and the one most candidates use is the National Institute of Open Schooling, which runs on-demand examinations. DGCA accepts NIOS marksheets for Computer Number issue, and airline cadet programmes state explicitly that NIOS scores are accepted - Air India asks for 60 per cent in 10+2 including 60 per cent in English, Mathematics and Physics, and confirms NIOS is accepted; IndiGo's partner schools ask for 51 per cent in each of the three subjects and likewise accept NIOS.

Two practical cautions. If your qualification is from a foreign or international board, you will need an equivalence certificate from the Association of Indian Universities; several cadet programmes state this explicitly. And get the equivalence position confirmed in writing before you pay a school deposit - a flying school cannot grant equivalence on DGCA's behalf.

The rule that may be about to change

In July 2025 the Ministry of Civil Aviation published draft rules under the Bharatiya Vayuyan Adhiniyam, 2024 - the Act that replaced the Aircraft Act, 1934 and came into force in January 2025 - proposing, among other things, that a commercial pilot licence could be granted after passing Class 10+2 even without Physics and Mathematics. As of 16 October 2026 the Centre told the Supreme Court that the rules had received administrative approval and would be published within two weeks, with the matter listed again on 16 November 2026.

That is a genuine possibility, and it is not yet law. Until the rules are actually notified, plan as though the Physics and Mathematics requirement applies. If you are deciding your Class 11 subjects this year, take Physics and Mathematics; if you are already past that point, the NIOS route is well-trodden and takes months, not years.

7 Class 2: the cheap first gate

Two thousand rupees of medical testing that can save you forty lakh. Do it in your final school year if you can.

A DGCA Class 2 medical assessment is conducted by a DGCA-authorised Class 2 medical examiner, and it is the entry gate: you need it before registering on the portal and before starting flight training, and it supports the student pilot stage. It covers general physical examination, vision and colour perception, and hearing, following the standards in ICAO Annex 1 Chapter 6 as implemented by DGCA.

Validity, under CAR Section 7 Series C Part I: Class 2 is valid for two years up to the age of 50, and one year thereafter. The examination includes a complete ophthalmic check with distance and near acuity, colour vision on Ishihara or Tokyo Medical College plates, and ocular muscle balance, plus ENT examination and pure tone audiometry, along with the usual blood, urine, ECG and imaging work where indicated.

The reason to do this early is not the certificate. It is the information. If the Ishihara plates go badly, you have learned the most important fact about your career for the price of a dinner for four, and before you have moved cities.

8 Class 1: what is tested, where, and for how long

The Class 1 medical is the single hardest gate in the whole process, and the only one you cannot study, buy or re-take your way around.

A Class 1 medical assessment is required for applicants and holders of a CPL or ATPL for aeroplanes and helicopters. The standards are those in ICAO Annex 1 Chapter 6, read with DGCA's own aeronautical information circulars, and the assessment is issued by DGCA's medical assessor after examination at an approved centre - the final certificate comes from the regulator, not from the doctor who examines you.

Table 3. What the Class 1 examination actually involves

System	What is checked
Eyes	Distance and near acuity, refraction, colour vision, depth perception, visual fields, dilated fundus examination
Ears, nose, throat	Pure tone audiometry, clinical ENT examination
Heart	Blood pressure, resting 12-lead ECG; treadmill and echo where indicated by age or findings
Lungs	Chest X-ray where indicated
Blood and urine	Haemoglobin and counts, fasting and post-meal sugar and HbA1c, lipid profile, liver and kidney function, urinalysis
Abdomen	Ultrasound of abdomen and pelvis
General	Height, weight, BMI, and cardiovascular, respiratory, abdominal and musculoskeletal examination
Neurological	Neurological examination; EEG or psychological screening where indicated

Initial issue is done at a limited set of centres. Under CAR Section 7 Series C Part I these include the Air Force Central Medical Establishment in New Delhi, the Institute of Aerospace Medicine in Bengaluru, the Medical Examination Centre (East) at Jorhat, Command Hospital Air Force Bengaluru, 11 Air Force Hospital at Hindon, 7 Air Force Hospital at Kanpur, Dr Balabhai Nanavati Hospital in Mumbai, and Apollo Heart Centre in Chennai. Renewals can be done at Indian Air Force boarding centres and by DGCA-empanelled Class 1 examiners.

Validity is the part candidates forget. A Class 1 is valid for one year up to the age of 60 and six-monthly thereafter; for single-crew operations the validity is six months above the age of 40. If your last Class 1 is more than two years old you need a fresh initial rather than a renewal. Because the licence depends on a current medical, an expired certificate grounds you even if nothing about your health has changed - so plan renewals around your flying, not the other way round.

Between the examination and the issue of the assessment, you fly on the CA-35 certificate issued by the examination centre. Under DGCA's medical assessment framework the certificate is what you carry, and a fit assessment must be issued before you exercise licence privileges again after a period of temporary unfitness.

9 Colour vision, glasses and LASIK: the hard stops

Three questions decide more careers than any written paper. Get authoritative answers to all three before you spend money.

Colour vision is the one to resolve first. DGCA screens with the Ishihara plates, and in India significant colour vision deficiency has historically been treated as disqualifying for a Class 1 - a stricter position than in some other jurisdictions, where secondary lantern tests give colour-deficient pilots a route through. Whether any secondary testing or concession applies to your specific case is genuinely case-specific and has changed over time. Do not take hope from American or European rules, and do not accept a forum answer either way: get assessed by a DGCA-approved examiner against the current CAR.

Spectacles are not a disqualification. Wearing glasses or contact lenses is entirely normal among airline pilots, provided your corrected acuity meets the standard and your refractive error falls inside DGCA's prescribed limits. DGCA has revised those limits over the years, so if your prescription is anywhere near a threshold, have it assessed professionally rather than comparing it to a number on a website.

Refractive surgery is more nuanced than either the optimistic or the pessimistic version you will read. LASIK and similar procedures are generally accepted subject to conditions - typically a post-operative waiting period, documented stability of refraction, and pre-operative records that the examiner can review. The practical implication is simple: if you are considering laser correction, get the pre-operative documentation and keep it, and tell the examiner rather than hoping it goes unnoticed.

One more thing worth knowing, because it reduces panic: many findings result in Temporarily Unfit rather than permanent rejection, with a defined window to treat and re-present. A high BMI, an abnormal ECG, a thyroid or sugar reading, a cyst on an ultrasound - these are commonly reviewed and resolved. Colour vision deficiency is the one that is generally not.

10 The order of operations

Sequence is not a detail. Done in the wrong order, the same steps cost you a deposit you cannot recover.

Table 4. The correct sequence, and why each step comes where it does

Order	Step	Why here
1	Ishihara colour vision check	Cheapest possible test of the one thing that can end the plan outright
2	Class 2 medical	Required to register and to start training; also confirms general fitness
3	Class 1 medical	Before any substantial payment. This is the expensive mistake to avoid
4	Computer Number on Pariksha	Free, lifetime, and needed for every exam and the RTR
5	Choose an FTO using the DGCA ranking	The ranking is published twice a year; check the current one
6	Negotiate and sign the trainee agreement	Now governed by DGCA's October 2026 guidelines - see section 21
7	Ground school and theory papers	Front-load them; cleared papers make you loan-friendly and free you for flying
8	Flight training to 200 hours	The long, weather-dependent middle
9	Skill tests and licence application	Within six months of the tests, with all documents in order
10	Type rating	Only when you know which aircraft the hiring market wants

The single most valuable line in that table is step 3. A candidate who books a Class 2 and, on clearing it, books an early Class 1 before paying a school has removed the largest catastrophic risk in Indian pilot training for a

few thousand rupees. A candidate who pays a deposit first and discovers a problem at the Class 1 has a commercial dispute on their hands.

PART THREE

DGCA Paperwork and Examinations

Five papers, one radio licence, two portals, and a fee structure that rewards planning. This is the part of the journey you can control completely.

11 Computer Number and the two portals

One free number, issued once, valid for life. Everything DGCA does with you afterwards runs through it.

The Computer Number is a unique identifier allotted by DGCA's Central Examination Organisation. You need it before you can sit any flight crew examination, before the RTR examination, and for the licence application itself. There is no fee for obtaining it, and a candidate is authorised to hold exactly one.

Two portals matter, and candidates confuse them constantly. Pariksha (pariksha.dgca.gov.in) is the registration and examination portal - it is where you apply for exam sessions, pay, download admit cards and see results. eGCA is the licensing platform - it is where medical assessments, English language proficiency, electronic logbooks and licence applications live, and it is the app through which your licence will eventually be displayed. The Pariksha portal's own description is that it integrates the earlier VIMAN and UDAAN systems, and that all candidates with a Computer Number must register on it to appear in future examinations.

Documents to have ready

- Class 10 and Class 12 marksheets and pass certificates, showing Physics and Mathematics for the CPL category
- Proof of date of birth
- Proof of address
- A recent photograph and your signature, in the specified format
- Your Class 2 medical certificate

Two process changes are worth knowing. DGCA abolished the requirement to post hard copies of documents to New Delhi, so the process is now online. And Computer Numbers are now auto-generated through DigiLocker for candidates from linked boards, which turns a wait of weeks into something much shorter where it applies.

> *Get your name and date of birth to match your Class 10 certificate exactly, character for character. Mismatches are the most common cause of a rejected application, and fixing them afterwards costs weeks you do not have.*

12 The five papers, and the myth of six

Ask ten candidates how many DGCA theory papers there are and you will get three different answers. Here is what the regulation actually says.

CAR Section 7 Series B Part I, which governs eligibility for flight crew examinations, sets out the CPL theoretical knowledge requirement as examinations in Air Navigation, Aviation Meteorology, Air Regulation, and aircraft and engine or instruments in general, specific, and performance where applicable. The performance paper applies to aeroplanes with a maximum take-off weight above 5,700 kg or to twin-engine helicopters, so for a candidate training on a light single-engine aircraft it does not arise at the CPL stage.

That gives five papers in practice:

1. Air Regulations - Indian and ICAO rules of the air, licensing, and the regulatory framework
2. Air Navigation - navigation, flight planning, instruments and radio aids
3. Aviation Meteorology - weather theory, charts, forecasts and their operational use
4. Technical General - airframes, engines, systems, principles of flight
5. Technical Specific - the specific aircraft type you train on

So where does 'six' come from? Two places. Radio Aids and Instruments is an ATPL subject, not a CPL one, and candidates who read an ATPL syllabus list assume it applies to them. And the RTR(A) radio telephony examination is a separate examination with its own rules, its own schedule and its own fee - it is mandatory for the licence, but it is not one of the five DGCA papers. If a school quotes you 'six subjects', it is usually counting the RTR alongside the five, which is a reasonable way to teach it but a confusing way to describe the regulation.

Table 5. The examination rules that matter

Rule	Position
Pass mark	70 per cent in each paper
Negative marking	None
Format	Computer-based, objective, in English, at DGCA centres
Order	Papers can be taken in any order and split across sessions
Validity of a pass	Five years - so plan the whole set inside that window
Sessions	Four regular sessions a year, plus eight on-demand (OLODE) sessions
Fee per paper	Rs 2,500 in a regular session, Rs 5,000 in an OLODE session
Refunds	Fees are not refundable and cannot be carried to a later session

Those last two lines deserve emphasis because they change behaviour. Because a fee is not refundable and cannot be carried forward, an application made in a session you end up missing is money gone. Because an OLODE attempt costs exactly double, the on-demand route is a tool for fixing a schedule problem, not a default.

13 Fees and the 2026 examination calendar

DGCA published its programme of examinations for 2026. Copy these dates into your calendar now, because a missed window costs months, not weeks.

Table 6. DGCA flight crew examination programme, 2026 (tentative per DGCA)

Session	Dates	Fee per paper
Regular Session 01	10 - 14 March 2026	Rs 2,500
Regular Session 02	16 - 20 June 2026	Rs 2,500
Regular Session 03	22 - 26 September 2026	Rs 2,500
Regular Session 04	15 - 19 December 2026	Rs 2,500
OLODE Session 1 - 8	January, February, April, May, July, August, October, November 2026	Rs 5,000

DGCA labels these dates tentative and subject to change for gazetted holidays and administrative reasons, and directs candidates to the notice board on the Pariksha portal for the current position. Application windows open roughly a month ahead of each session and close at 22:00 on the closing date; the portal will not accept a late form.

Fees are paid through Bharatkosh after you complete the application, and DGCA advises paying by 23:00 on the closing date because a payment confirmed after midnight may not be counted. If a payment fails, wait at least an hour before retrying. There is one narrow refund route - where Bharatkosh took the money but DGCA delivered no service, you can apply through your Pariksha login with a self-attested copy of the receipt and identity proof.

The oral examination fee is a separate Rs 500 per oral paper, and it applies only from the second and third attempt. It is worth knowing that because it tells you something about how DGCA expects candidates to behave: a first attempt at the oral is included, and repeats are charged.

14 A study plan that finishes in four sessions

The papers are not hard. They are voluminous, and they punish candidates who sequence them badly.

The single most common scheduling error is trying to sit all five at once and then losing a session because one paper went badly. The second most common is leaving the technical papers until after flight training, when your study time has evaporated into a flying roster.

A sequence that works for most candidates, and that fits inside the four regular sessions of a year:

- Session 1 - Air Regulations and Aviation Meteorology. Air Regulations has the shortest syllabus and is the most rules-based, so it rewards a methodical read. Meteorology is descriptive and pairs well with it.
- Session 2 - Air Navigation. The most numerical paper; give it a full cycle on its own, and practise the plotting and flight-planning problems until they are mechanical.
- Session 3 - Technical General. Airframes, engines, systems and principles of flight. Heavy, but the most teachable paper in the set.
- Session 4 - Technical Specific, plus any retake. Taken close to your flying so the aircraft is fresh in your mind.
- Alongside all of it - RTR(A). It shares ground with Air Regulations and Meteorology, so study it in the same window rather than as a separate project.

Three habits separate the candidates who clear in four sessions from those who take eight. First, ground school before flying, not during: an exam-cleared candidate is available for sorties when the aircraft is serviceable, while a candidate sitting papers disappears for weeks at exactly the moment the roster opens up. Second, mock tests under time pressure, because the paper is 70 per cent and objective - close is not a pass. Third, a written record of every paper's validity date, because a pass expires in five years and a long training delay can quietly put your earliest paper out of date.

15 RTR(A): the exam DGCA took over

On 1 December 2025 the radio telephony licence moved from the telecom side of government to the aviation regulator. Most study material has not caught up.

The Radio Telephone Operator (Restricted) Certificate and Licence - RTR(A) for aeronautical use - is mandatory for a CPL. Until recently it was examined by the Wireless Planning and Coordination wing of the Department of Telecommunications. Under the Radio Telephone Operator (Restricted) Certificate and Licence Rules, 2025 and CAR Section 7 Series G Part VI, DGCA took over both the examination and the issue of the certificate and licence with effect from 1 December 2025. A public notice dated 6 July 2026 confirmed that RTR certificates or licences issued or renewed by WPC up to 15 July 2026 are accepted, and that all new services are to be obtained through DGCA's procedures.

The examination has two parts, and they are marked differently:

Table 7. The RTR(A) examination under DGCA

Part	Format	Pass mark	Validity and attempts
Written	50 multiple-choice questions, computer-based, in English	70 per cent	Pass valid for three years
Practical	About 30 minutes in a simulated radiotelephony environment	50 per cent	Three attempts in total

The syllabus is published as Annexure A to the CAR and is organised in three blocks: regulations and procedures, radio principles and practice, and radiotelephony communication procedures. The regulations block covers the ITU and ICAO framework, Q-codes, the phonetic alphabet, distress and urgency procedures, licensing of radio apparatus, Indian flight information regions and their principal frequencies, meteorological codes and NOTAMs. The principles block covers electrical units, wavelength and frequency, propagation, HF and VHF, intercommunication systems and radio navigation aids. The radiotelephony block is the operational heart of it: standard words and phrases, call signs, clearance and readback discipline, aerodrome, approach and area control phraseology, and communications failure procedures.

The practical is where prepared candidates and well-read candidates separate. It runs as a sequence of simulated scenarios across the phases of flight - start-up, taxi, departure, en route, arrival and an emergency - and you cannot go back to a scenario you have skipped. Standard ICAO phraseology is mandatory; casual language costs marks. Readbacks must be accurate and complete. The way to prepare is to say the calls out loud, repeatedly, until the sequence is automatic under mild pressure - not to read them.

Fees for both parts are set under Rule 9 of the 2025 Rules and are paid through the Pariksha portal and, for the practical, through Bharatkosh on eGCA. Confirm the current amount on the portal when you apply rather than relying on any older figure, including any figure you have seen quoted elsewhere.

PART FOUR

Flight Training

Where the money goes and where the timeline slips. The regulation is precise, the market is not, and the difference between a good school and a bad one is measured in months of your life.

16 Student Pilot Licence, FRTOL and your first hours

The SPL is not a licence you shop for separately. It is a training-stage authorisation your school handles once you are medically cleared and enrolled.

You need a valid Class 2 medical before flight training begins and before the student stage is processed. The school conducts the student-stage ground and oral checks and completes the SPL formalities; you do not need to obtain a Private Pilot Licence on the way to a CPL, and a PPL is not a required intermediate step. The FRTOL - the Flight Radio Telephone Operator's Licence - is part of the radio-licensing record, and in the normal India-trained route the school handles or forwards the application formalities once the relevant requirements are met.

Your first hours are dual instruction: effects of controls, straight and level, climbing and descending, turning, stalling, slow flight, and then circuits. Then the first solo - typically somewhere between ten and twenty hours, depending on you and on the weather. Then solo consolidation, then cross-country navigation, then night flying and instrument work.

Two things about this phase are worth knowing in advance. First, hours accumulate unevenly: a fortnight of monsoon can cost you ten flyable days, and no school can refund you the calendar. Second, the hourly rate is not the whole hourly cost - landing and parking fees, instructor time and fuel surcharges are often separate lines, which is exactly what the DGCA's October 2026 guidelines now require schools to disclose up front.

17 The 200 hours, decoded

'200 hours' is the headline. The sub-requirements underneath it are where candidates discover a shortfall three weeks before their skill test.

Under Section J of Schedule II of the Aircraft Rules, 1937, an applicant for a CPL (Aeroplanes) must produce evidence of having completed, as pilot of an aeroplane within the five years immediately preceding the application, not less than 200 hours of flight time, which must include each of the following.

Table 8. The 200 hours, requirement by requirement

Requirement	Minimum	The detail that catches people
Total flight time	200 hours	Counted within the five years before you apply
Pilot-in-command time	100 hours	Of which at least 15 hours must be in the six months before applying
Cross-country as PIC	20 hours	Must include one flight of at least 300 nautical miles with full-stop landings at two different aerodromes
Instrument time	10 hours	Not more than 5 of these may be on an approved simulator
Night flying	5 hours	With at least 10 take-offs and 10 landings as PIC, as sole manipulator of controls, in the six months before applying

Requirement	Minimum	The detail that catches people
Skill tests	Within 6 months	Day and night general flying tests, a day cross-country of at least 250 nm with a full-stop landing elsewhere, and a night cross-country of at least 120 nm returning without landing
Radio licence	Current FRTOL	Issued by DGCA; without it the licence is not issued

Read the right-hand column again, because that is where the money and the time hide. The 15 PIC hours in the last six months, the 10 night take-offs and landings in the last six months, and the four flight tests all sit inside a six-month recency window. A candidate who finishes 200 hours and then waits four months for a skill test slot can find their recency has decayed and they are paying for hours they have already flown once.

Two structural points follow. First, track your own totals against this table from day one - a logbook you can audit is worth more than a school's reassurance. Second, plan the endgame backwards from your intended application date: skill tests, the 15 PIC hours, the night currency and the licence paperwork all have to land inside the same window.

18 Skill tests and the licence application

The last mile is administrative, and administrative failures are the most annoying kind.

A DGCA-approved examiner conducts the skill test and an oral examination covering airmanship, regulations and aircraft systems. Schedule it only when all five theory papers are cleared, the RTR is in hand, the Class 1 is current and the 200 hours with their sub-requirements are complete - turning up with one item missing wastes a slot you waited weeks for.

The application itself goes through eGCA, with the consolidated logbook, the exam pass certificates, the RTR licence, the valid Class 1 and the skill test report. Check names, dates, aircraft registrations, logbook totals and recency before you submit; DGCA may raise a deficiency if something is incomplete, and each deficiency costs a cycle.

Then the licence arrives as an Electronic Personnel Licence. India launched the EPL for pilots on 20 February 2025, becoming the second country in the world to do so after China, following ICAO's Amendment 178 to Annex 1. Under DGCA's Flight Crew Licensing Circular it applies to CPLs and FRTOLs issued on or after 15 January 2025, with renewals of CPL and instrument rating and regeneration of FRTOL added from 2 June 2025, and ATPL added on 21 January 2026. The EPL is displayed only through the eGCA mobile app, requires a device running Android 5.0 or iOS 11 or above, can be registered on a maximum of two devices, and works offline after one online login. Existing hard copy licences are deemed invalid once an EPL is generated on renewal.

> *Practically: keep your eGCA credentials safe, keep the app installed and logged in, and sync it online at least once a quarter. A pilot who cannot display a licence at a ramp check because the app has not synced has a problem that has nothing to do with flying.*

19 Choosing an FTO: the ranking, decoded

Since October 2025 there has been an official answer to 'which flying school?'. It is published twice a year, and it is the first thing to look at.

DGCA announced the ranking framework by public notice on 8 July 2025 and published the first phase on 30 September 2025. The second phase, covering the period 1 March 2025 to 28 February 2026, was released on 24 April 2026. The grading is by score band: A+ at 85 per cent and above, A from 70 to below 85, B from 50 to below 70, and C below 50. FTOs in Category C receive a notice from DGCA requiring self-analysis and corrective action. FTOs that had not completed eighteen months since approval as on 28 February 2026 were excluded from that phase.

The headline result of the April 2026 phase was that exactly one of the 35 ranked organisations reached Category A - Avyanna Aviation - up from a first phase in which no school qualified for the top grade at all. Seventeen organisations sat in Category B and seventeen in Category C. IGRUA, the Ministry's own academy, moved from C to B.

Table 9. DGCA FTO ranking, April 2026 (35 ranked organisations)

Category	Flying training organisations
A	Avyanna Aviation Pvt. Ltd
B	Academy of Carver Aviation; FSTC Flying School Pvt. Ltd; National Flying Training Institute Pvt. Ltd; Indira Gandhi Rashtriya Uran Akademi; Flytech Aviation Academy; Skynex Aero Pvt Ltd; Garg Aviation Ltd; Chetak Aviation Pvt. Ltd; Chimes Aviation Academy; Dunes Aviation Academy; Ekvi Air Training Organisation Pvt. Ltd; Jet Serve Aviation Pvt. Ltd; Alchemist Aviation Pvt. Ltd; Ambition Flying Club; Orient Flight Aviation Academy; The Bombay Flying Club; The Gujarat Flying Club
C	Sha Shib Flying Academy; Indian Flying Academy; The Madhya Pradesh Flying Club; Wings Aviation Pvt Ltd; Asia Pacific Training Academy; Haryana Institute of Civil Aviation; Rajiv Gandhi Academy for Aviation Technology; Telangana State Aviation Academy; The Nagpur Flying Club; Banasthali Vidyapith Gliding & Flying Club; Bihar Flying Institute; Patiala Aviation Club; SVKM NMIMS Academy of Aviation; BlueRay Aviation Pvt Ltd; Pioneer Flying Club Academy Pvt Ltd; Govt. Aviation Training Institute; Redbird Flight Training Academy Pvt. Ltd

Read the ranking for what it is and for what it is not. It is a comparison of operational performance over a defined year, scored by the regulator - a genuinely useful signal that did not exist two years ago. It is not a placement guarantee, it is not a price list, and a Category B school can be the right school for you if it is near your home, flies consistently, and will finish you in twenty months. What the ranking does do is make one question legitimate that used to be awkward: if a school is in Category C, ask it, politely and in writing, what DGCA found.

20 Nine questions to ask before you sign

Ask these in writing, and keep the replies. A school that will not put answers in writing has told you something.

1. How many aircraft are serviceable today, and how many are on your register?
2. What is your current student-to-aircraft ratio, and how many students are waiting for sorties?
3. For students who enrolled two years ago, what was the average months-to-CPL, not the advertised one?
4. Is your DGCA approval current today, and what category were you in the April 2026 ranking?
5. Which aircraft types will I fly, and does your fleet include a multi-engine type or will I be sent elsewhere for those hours?
6. Does the quoted fee include landing and parking fees, fuel surcharge, examiner fees, simulator time and accommodation?
7. Who are your instructors, how many are current, and what is your instructor retention over the last year?
8. What is your refund policy in writing, and how does it map to the DGCA guidelines of October 2026?
9. Will you give me the contact details of three students who finished in the last eighteen months?

The fourth question is the one candidates are shy about, and it is the most important. DGCA suspends and restricts FTOs, and a suspended school can still run a website, still advertise, and still take a deposit. Verify approval status on DGCA's site on the day you pay, not on the day you first visited.

21 The contract: DGCA's October 2026 protections

On 5 October 2026 DGCA issued Flying Training Circular 02 of 2026 - guidelines for agreements between flying training organisations and trainees. It is the most useful document a trainee pilot has ever been handed, and almost nobody has read it.

The circular's stated purpose is to ensure a transparent, fair and just process for trainee induction, training fee, refund, transfer and training records, and it applies to all DGCA-approved FTOs and their trainees. DGCA is explicit that it is not regulating the private contractual relationship in its entirety and will not act as an adjudicator for purely commercial disputes - but it does set out what the agreement must contain, and non-compliance is dealt with under CAR Section 7 Series D Part I, with restriction or stoppage of trainee intake among the available measures.

What must be disclosed before enrolment

At enrolment the school must give you, in writing, as part of the agreement and signed by both parties: the course of training and its applicable regulatory requirements; the estimated duration; the flying hours and ground training requirements; the aircraft types to be used; the fee structure and payment schedule; the refund policy; charges other than flying fees; the conditions relating to discontinuation and transfer; and the grievance redressal mechanism. The information on the school's website must be consistent with the arrangements that apply to you. For a minor, a parent or guardian signs.

The fee rules - the part that changes everything

The total prescribed flying training is ordinarily to be divided into four progressive blocks of 25 per cent each, with the fee for each block payable as training progresses. The school may not demand payment for the next block until the preceding block has been completed or substantially utilised. You may not be required to deposit the entire course or flying fee in advance, and at any stage the advance payment for flying training may not exceed the fee for the next 25 per cent block. The block-wise schedule must be disclosed before enrolment and written into your agreement.

That single paragraph dismantles the most common financial trap in Indian pilot training: paying seventy per cent of a flying fee up front to a school whose aircraft are on the ground. If a school asks you for the whole amount in advance, it is asking you to do something the regulator has now told it not to ask.

Refunds

Every FTO must publish a refund policy under CAR 7/D/I, and that policy must be transparent, fair, reasonable and non-arbitrary. Critically, a standard agreement may no longer contain a blanket provision making the entire training fee non-refundable under all circumstances. The school may retain amounts corresponding to training actually provided, but the unutilised fee is ordinarily refundable, subject to reasonable and clearly disclosed charges. The refund calculation must show the total received, the training utilised, the amount attributable to services already provided, any other deductions with their basis, and the net refundable amount - and a refund should ordinarily be processed within 15 working days after the required formalities.

Where a transfer is sought for reasons substantially attributable to the school, you are ordinarily entitled to a refund of the entire unutilised training fee. The circular lists the circumstances: the school's inability to provide training in line with the agreed duration; suspension, cancellation or cessation of its approval; a material unilateral alteration of agreed fees or essential training conditions that you do not accept; material misrepresentation about training capacity or facilities at enrolment; or persistent school-related disruption affecting continuity or quality. If you move purely by personal preference, the published refund policy and agreed terms apply instead.

Transfer, records and grievances

A trainee may seek transfer to another DGCA-approved FTO under CAR 7/D/I. The outgoing school must release training records and documentation with an NOC, must provide a statement of financial settlement, and may not use a fee dispute to withhold training records. Every FTO must run an internal grievance mechanism, record and acknowledge each grievance, and ordinarily respond within seven working days. Safety and regulatory complaints are handled separately from commercial disputes, and a trainee may not be treated adversely for raising a safety concern in good faith.

One limitation to understand clearly: for training outside India, DGCA has said that refunds, financial disputes and contractual disagreements with foreign schools are outside its purview. The circular's protections are an Indian-school protection. If you train abroad, your only remedy is the foreign jurisdiction.

The five-line contract checklist

Does the agreement state the estimated duration, aircraft types and hours in writing?

Is the flying fee split into four 25 per cent blocks, with no demand ahead of the block being flown?

Is there any blanket 'non-refundable' clause? If so, ask them to remove it and cite the circular.

Is the refund calculation method, and the 15-working-day timeline, written into the agreement?

Do you have a mutually signed copy, and receipts for every payment you have made?

22 Red flags: how pilot training money disappears

The patterns are repetitive enough to list. Recognising them early is worth more than any negotiation later.

- A fee demanded in full, or at a large discount for 'upfront payment'. The 25 per cent block rule exists precisely to stop this.
- A school whose approval is suspended or restricted, or whose ranking is Category C and cannot explain why. Verify status on DGCA's site on the day you pay.
- Guaranteed-job language. No flying school can guarantee an airline job, and airline cadet programmes themselves describe employment as subject to the airline's requirements.
- A completion timeline presented as a promise rather than an estimate. Ask for the realised average of students who enrolled two years ago.
- No written agreement, or an agreement you are shown only after paying a deposit.
- Aircraft that are 'on the register' rather than serviceable. Ask how many flew this week.
- Pressure to skip the Class 1 medical because 'it can be done later'.
- A foreign school with no clear conversion plan, and no written refund terms in a jurisdiction you can enforce.
- Fee increases announced mid-course. Under the circular, material terms cannot be altered unilaterally in a way materially prejudicial to you, and no change may be retrospective.

23 India or abroad?

Forty per cent of CPLs since 2016 went to foreign-trained cadets. That share is now falling, and the reasons are worth understanding.

Training abroad is not inherently better or worse. What differs is the dependency chain. A foreign route adds a student visa, foreign-student security vetting where the destination requires it, appointment availability and administrative processing - none of which you control, and none of which a school can promise. It also adds a conversion step on return: under CAR Section 7 Series G Part I, a foreign CPL is converted to an Indian licence

through examinations in Air Regulation and a composite Air Navigation and Meteorology paper, plus skill tests in India on at least one aircraft type to be endorsed, plus an Indian Class 1, plus verified original logbooks meeting the same 200 hour and sub-requirement tests. Where the foreign licence does not carry an instrument rating, the instrument rating skill test must be done in India.

The Ministry's own data shows the balance shifting: of the 1,331 CPLs issued to 30 June 2026, 791 came from Indian FTOs and 540 from foreign ones, and capacity in India is expanding with 11 new FTO slots tendered at AAI airports in 2026. For most candidates the domestic route is now the simpler one, with two exceptions worth naming: a specific foreign school with a genuine airline pathway and a contract you can enforce, and a cadet programme that places you abroad as part of a structured, airline-backed pipeline.

If you do go abroad, apply the same discipline as at home: verify the school's approval with the foreign regulator, get the refund terms in writing, budget the conversion months and their cost, and understand that DGCA will not intervene in a dispute with a foreign school.

24 Multi-engine and instrument rating

A CPL earned only on a single-engine aircraft is a licence that no airline can use.

Airlines operate multi-engine jets in instrument conditions. Your licence therefore needs a multi-engine endorsement and an instrument rating before a jet job is realistic, and Indian airlines state the requirement plainly: IndiGo's Junior First Officer criteria require a DGCA CPL with an A320 endorsement, current COP or RTR, FRTO and Class 1 medical, and a multi-engine endorsement with a minimum of 25 hours of multi-engine time, of which at least 15 hours must be on an actual aircraft and no more than 10 on a simulator.

This is where a headline 'CPL fee' most often misleads. Multi-engine hours cost substantially more per hour than single-engine hours, and many quoted packages include single-engine flying only. Ask, in writing, how many multi-engine hours and how much instrument time the quoted fee includes, and whether the instrument rating skill test is included.

PART FIVE

The First Job

The licence gets you into the queue. This part is about the two things that move you to the front of it: the right type rating, and a selection process you have prepared for.

25 What airlines actually ask for

Airline career pages are unusually specific. Read them before you spend money on a rating, because they tell you which aircraft the market wants.

Table 10. Entry-level requirements as published by airlines

Airline	Role	What is required
IndiGo	Junior First Officer	Age 18-40; Indian national; DGCA CPL with A320 endorsement; current COP or RTR, FRTO and Class 1 medical; multi-engine endorsement with at least 25 hours, of which at least 15 on aircraft and at most 10 on simulator; no accident or incident record
IndiGo	First Officer	Maximum age 45; valid DGCA CPL with A320 endorsement; current FRTO, RTR, Class 1 and valid ratings; line released as First Officer on the A320 family with at least 200 hours post line release
IndiGo	Senior First Officer	Maximum age 55; current DGCA ATPL; current FRTO, RTR and Class 1; 200 hours post line release on the A320 family
IndiGo	Captain and above	Maximum age 62; DGCA ATPL with A320 PIC endorsement; total flying time of 3,000 hours with at least 100 hours as PIC post line release on the A320 family
Air India group	Cadet entry	Indian citizen or OCI; 18-30; 60 per cent in 10+2 with 60 per cent in English, Mathematics and Physics; minimum height 158 cm; DGCA Class 1 before flight training

Two things follow from that table. First, the A320 endorsement appears in almost every entry requirement in the country, because IndiGo, Air India and Air India Express all operate large A320-family fleets. Second, the ATPL appears at Senior First Officer level - which tells you that your first upgrade milestone is not a promotion you wait for, it is a set of papers you sit once you have the hours.

26 Type rating: the Rs 25 lakh decision

No regulator publishes a type rating price. That absence of an official rate card is why the same question produces answers 20 lakh apart.

DGCA regulates the training standard - ground school hours, simulator sessions, the final skill test - but it does not set or publish the price a training organisation charges to deliver it. There is no equivalent of the Rs 2,500 per paper that Pariksha prints in black and white. Every figure you read, including these, is a market estimate assembled from providers and student reports.

With that caveat stated plainly: an Airbus A320 type rating in India is generally quoted in the region of Rs 15 to 30 lakh, and a Boeing 737 rating somewhat lower. Around the rating itself sit costs people forget - a multi-crew coordination or jet orientation course, a licence endorsement fee, and sometimes an airline preparation course - which together can add several lakh more. IGRUA's published 2026 figure for an optional type rating with its FSTC partner was Rs 17,00,000 for A320 or B737 and Rs 19,00,000 for ATR-72 or Q400, which is as close to an official anchor as the market offers.

Self-sponsored versus bonded

There are two ways to acquire a rating, and they carry opposite risks. Self-sponsored means you pay, you own the rating, and you are free to apply anywhere - with no guarantee that anyone hires you, and the risk that you bought a rating for an aircraft the hiring market did not want that year. Bonded means an airline or cadet programme funds or bundles the rating in exchange for a service commitment, typically several years, with early exit usually requiring repayment.

The decision rule is unglamorous. If a structured programme with an employment letter is available and you can finance it, the bond is usually the better trade, because it converts an open market bet into a defined path. If you are self-funding, buy the rating only when a specific airline is actively hiring on that type - which, in India in 2026, means the A320 family far more often than anything else.

> *Ask for the full written quote, itemised, before you pay: ground school, simulator hours, the skill test, the endorsement fee, accommodation and any re-validation charges. A single all-in number from a provider that will not itemise it is not a quote, it is an opening position.*

27 Cadet programmes: Air India and IndiGo

The fastest route and the most expensive one. Both major airlines run them, and their published terms are quite different.

Table 11. The two big cadet routes, as published

	Air India Cadet Pilot Programme	IndiGo cadet programmes
Who can apply	Indian citizen or OCI; age 18-30	Indian national or OCI; age limits vary by partner - IndiGo's own guide states 18-32, several partner pages state 18-40
Education	60 per cent in 10+2, with 60 per cent in English, Mathematics and Physics; NIOS accepted	51 per cent in Physics, Mathematics and English individually; NIOS accepted
Medical	DGCA Class 1 before flight training begins	Class 2 acceptable to apply; Class 1 before signing the agreement
Other	Minimum height 158 cm; good written and spoken English	Valid Indian passport; some partners require a criminal record check and a BMI certificate; visible tattoos usually disqualify
Where you train	Air India Flying Academy at Amravati, plus partner schools in the United States	Partner schools in India and abroad, including Chimes Aviation Academy, Garuda Aviation, Marigold, Skyborne, Flight Training Adelaide and Insight Aviation
Duration	About 24 months including type rating	About 19-21 months including A320 type rating, plus 2-3 months for documentation
Selection	Application screening, online assessment, personal interview	Written Mathematics, Physics and English, then the ADAPT psychometric and aptitude suite, a group task, and a panel interview
What you get	CPL plus type rating, and an employment offer to join a group airline as a trainee pilot, subject to the airline's requirements	CPL plus A320 type rating, and a letter of intent to join as a Junior First Officer
Cost	Disclosed to enrolled candidates before training; a financing partner is available	Varies by partner. Published examples include about Rs 104 lakh at one Indian partner and about USD 131,000 at another

Three things to be clear-eyed about. First, these are competitive selections with aptitude testing, and reapplication is limited - Air India applies a three-month cooling-off period after an assessment. Second, an employment offer is not an unconditional guarantee: Air India's own wording is that it will offer successful cadets

employment 'subject to change as per airline's pilot trajectory'. Third, the cost is real and usually loan-funded, so Part Six matters more on this route than on any other.

The advantage is equally real. A structured programme removes the two risks that destroy self-sponsored candidates: the risk of training that never finishes, and the risk of finishing with a licence nobody is hiring.

28 The selection process: ADAPT, group task, interview

Airline selection is not an examination. It is an assessment of whether you are safe to put in a cockpit with another human being.

IndiGo's published process is the most detailed and is a good proxy for the sector. Candidates sit a written assessment in Mathematics, Physics and English, then the ADAPT suite - an online psychometric and aptitude battery covering English, progressive mathematics and physics, control and coordination, cognitive reasoning, a personality questionnaire, and a flight test element. Successful candidates then attend a group task assessment run by airline panelists, and finally a personal interview. Each stage permits a maximum of two attempts.

Air India's structure is similar in spirit: application screening, an online assessment of cognitive and behavioural skills, then a personal interview, with technical evaluation covering critical thinking, numerical reasoning, performance under pressure, motor skills and spatial awareness, and non-technical evaluation covering collaboration and group dynamics.

You cannot cram coordination. What you can do is prepare the parts that are preparation-friendly: numerical and physics fundamentals at 10+2 level, mental arithmetic under time pressure, and a clear, honest account of why you want this. The interview is where candidates undo a good assessment by reciting a brochure. Panelists are listening for judgement, humility and self-awareness, because those are the qualities that make a first officer safe to fly with.

29 What you will earn

Indian airlines do not publish pay scales. Every number below is drawn from public reporting and pilot-community data, and should be read as indicative rather than authoritative.

The structure matters more than the number. Pilot pay in India is typically a fixed component plus a flying allowance per block hour plus layover allowances. IndiGo's model is distinctive in committing a monthly cost-to-company benchmarked against 70 hours of flying, with steps at flying-hour thresholds; Air India and Akasa are reported to fix pay at 40 hours and add hourly flying allowance on top. That difference means headline figures are not directly comparable across airlines unless you normalise to the same hours.

Table 12. Indicative monthly gross pay in 2026, from public reporting

Stage	Indicative monthly gross	Notes
Trainee or Junior First Officer under training	Rs 50,000 to 1 lakh stipend	Ground, simulator, base and line training before release
Junior First Officer, first year	Rs 1 lakh to 2.7 lakh	Wide range because structures differ; one airline's published JFO year-one figure is about Rs 2.35 lakh
First Officer	Rs 2.3 lakh to 3.5 lakh	Depends on hours flown and whether the airline guarantees 40 or 70 hours
Senior First Officer	Rs 3.4 lakh to 4.9 lakh	Generally ATPL held
Captain	Rs 4.75 lakh to 8.5 lakh	Commander grades at the upper end
Training or check captain	Rs 9.7 lakh to 10.5 lakh	Instructor and check airman scales

Two honest caveats. These are gross, pre-tax figures, and at these income levels effective deduction is substantial, so take-home is meaningfully lower than the headline. And the low end is real: a first-year junior first officer at a low-cost carrier may take home around a lakh a month after tax, which against a Rs 70 lakh training

loan is a tight few years. Plan the repayment against the low end of the range, and treat anything above it as upside.

30 Your first three years: line training to captain

Getting hired is the start of a training pipeline, not the end of one.

After induction you complete ground training, simulator sessions, base training - typically a handful of take-offs and landings on an actual aircraft - and then line training of roughly 100 hours or 70 sectors, split between pilot flying and pilot monitoring duties, ending in a final competency check before you are released as a functioning first officer. During this period you are on a stipend, not a full salary.

Once released, the milestones are hour-driven. The ATPL becomes available to you as a CPL holder, and airlines treat it as the gate to senior first officer and then command: IndiGo's Senior First Officer criteria require a current DGCA ATPL, and its Captain criteria require a total of 3,000 hours with at least 100 hours as PIC post line release on the type. In practical terms, most pilots who stay with a growing airline reach command in the better part of a decade, and the pace depends far more on the airline's fleet growth than on individual merit.

The habit that serves people well in this phase is boring and reliable: keep your own records. Logbook, medical validity, rating renewals, RTR currency and ELP. An administrative lapse grounds a pilot just as effectively as a technical one, and it is entirely avoidable.

PART SIX

The Money

Almost nobody pays for pilot training from savings. This part is about borrowing sensibly, understanding what the repayment actually feels like, and insuring the one risk you cannot absorb.

31 Financing: what banks actually offer

Pilot training is an eligible course under the standard education loan schemes of India's public sector banks. The differences between them are in the ceiling, the collateral, and the moratorium.

SBI's Student Loan Scheme lists regular degree and diploma courses including commercial pilot training approved by the Director General of Civil Aviation as eligible, and covers fees, examination and laboratory charges, books and equipment, caution deposits and travel. Bank of Baroda's Baroda Gyan scheme goes further and publishes a separate aviation ceiling. Both require a parent or guardian as co-borrower, and both price collateral.

Table 13. Education loan terms for pilot training, from bank scheme pages

	SBI Student Loan	Bank of Baroda Baroda Gyan
Ceiling for study in India	Rs 50 lakh for other courses, with higher limits considered case by case	Rs 125 lakh for aviation and medical courses
Collateral	None up to Rs 7.5 lakh with parent as co-borrower; tangible collateral above that	None up to Rs 7.5 lakh; tangible collateral of 100 per cent of the loan from Rs 7.5 lakh to Rs 80 lakh; 1.25 times cover above Rs 80 lakh
Margin	Nil up to Rs 4 lakh; 5 per cent above, for study in India	Nil up to Rs 4 lakh; 5 per cent above
Moratorium	Course period plus one year, or six months after getting a job, whichever is earlier	Course period plus moratorium, as per scheme terms
Repayment	Up to 15 years after the course plus moratorium	10 to 15 years after the moratorium
Indicative rate	10.15 per cent without collateral, 9.65 per cent with collateral; 0.50 per cent concession for girl students	From BRLLR plus 0.25 per cent for study in India
Processing fee	Nil up to Rs 20 lakh; Rs 10,000 plus taxes above	No processing charge up to Rs 7.5 lakh
Where to apply	Vidya Lakshmi or Jan Samarth portal, then the branch	Branch or online

Private lenders operate in this market too, typically at higher rates with more documentation flexibility, and some cadet programmes have a nominated financing partner that pre-agrees terms against the airline's letter of intent. Air India states that selected cadets can access special benefits with financial institutions it has collaborated with, while remaining free to choose another lender; IndiGo's partner programmes state that associated banks may lend up to 90 per cent of course fees subject to individual eligibility.

Three practical points from the scheme documents. Apply through the Vidya Lakshmi or Jan Samarth portal, because public sector banks route education loan applications through it and SBI commits to disposing of a complete application within 15 days. Offer collateral even below the threshold if you have it - it buys a lower rate. And clear some DGCA papers before applying: a candidate with passes on the board is a visibly lower risk than one with only an admission letter.

32 The loan maths, and the downside case

A loan of this size is not a fee, it is a decade of monthly payments. Look at the number before you sign, not after you qualify.

Take a Rs 60 lakh loan at around 9.65 per cent over 15 years with a moratorium of course period plus one year. Interest accrues during the moratorium; if you do not service it, it capitalises into the principal and the EMI is calculated on the larger amount. That single mechanic is why the same loan costs very different amounts to two families.

Table 14. Indicative EMI by loan size (15-year repayment, about 9.65 per cent, before moratorium interest capitalisation)

Loan	Approximate EMI	What it implies
Rs 40 lakh	About Rs 42,000 per month	Comfortable on a first officer salary if you are single and renting modestly
Rs 60 lakh	About Rs 63,000 per month	Manageable on a released first officer's pay, tight on a training stipend
Rs 80 lakh	About Rs 84,000 per month	Requires a first officer salary at the upper end of the band, or family support
Rs 1 crore	About Rs 1.05 lakh per month	Consumes most of a junior first officer's take-home. Plan for this before, not after

The figures are illustrative, calculated at a fixed rate to show shape rather than precision; your bank's amortisation will differ with the actual rate, the moratorium and whether you service interest during training. Use the bank's own calculator for the real number, and ask specifically what happens to accrued interest during the moratorium.

The downside case nobody models

Model three scenarios before borrowing. The base case - you qualify, get hired within a year of finishing, and start at the lower end of the first officer band. The slow case - you qualify but wait two years for a seat, during which the loan is in repayment and you are earning something else. And the stop case - you are declared unfit at a medical review, or the school's approval lapses, or the family's income changes. The stop case is the one that decides whether the collateral structure is sane. If losing the training would cost the family home, the structure is not sane.

This is exactly why the sequence in Part Two puts the Class 1 medical before any substantial payment, and why the October 2026 DGCA contract guidelines matter so much: the 25 per cent block rule and the refund provisions exist to cap your exposure if the stop case happens through no fault of yours.

33 Insurance, taxes and the family conversation

Two financial products and one conversation. All three are usually skipped, and all three are cheap to get right.

The insurance that matters is a term life cover on the co-borrower, sized to the outstanding loan, because the loan is secured on family assets. A credit-life policy assigned in favour of the bank is explicitly a financeable expense under SBI's scheme, which tells you the bank expects it. Personal accident cover for the trainee is the second piece - a training injury that interrupts flying is a real, if uncommon, risk.

On tax: education loan interest is deductible under the Income Tax Act for loans taken for higher education, and the section numbers have been renumbered under the Income Tax Act, 2025, which came into force for the current tax year. Confirm the current section with a tax professional or the Income Tax Department's own material before you rely on it in a return - this is exactly the kind of detail that changes.

The family conversation is the one that actually determines outcomes. Put three numbers on a single sheet: the total cost including the type rating, the monthly EMI in the base case, and the monthly income in the first year. If the third number does not comfortably cover the second plus rent, the plan needs a smaller loan or a cadet

programme with a bundled rating, not more optimism.

PART SEVEN

Tools

The calendar, the checklists, the scorecard and the answers. Everything in this part is meant to be used rather than read.

34 The 24-month action plan

A sequence that puts the medical, the money and the paperwork in the right order. Adjust the months to your own start date, not the other way round.

Table 15. The plan

When	What you do
Month 0	Ishihara colour vision check. Read DGCA's current CAR Section 7 Series C Part I and the current FTO ranking. Open a spreadsheet for the budget.
Month 0-1	Class 2 medical. If it clears, book the Class 1 at an approved centre. Do not pay any school deposit yet.
Month 1-2	Apply for the Computer Number on Pariksha. Get name and date of birth to match the Class 10 certificate exactly. Register on eGCA.
Month 2-3	Shortlist three FTOs from the current ranking. Visit at least two. Ask the nine questions in section 20 in writing.
Month 3	Sanction the education loan, or confirm family funding. Read the trainee agreement against the checklist in section 21 before signing.
Month 3-4	Join ground school. Sit Air Regulations and Aviation Meteorology in the first available regular session.
Month 4-6	Student Pilot Licence formalities. Begin flying. Sit Air Navigation in the next session.
Month 6-9	Solo, consolidation, cross-country navigation. Sit Technical General. Start RTR preparation alongside.
Month 9-12	Night flying and instrument work. Sit RTR(A) written and practical. Sit Technical Specific.
Month 12-18	Build to 200 hours with the sub-requirements in section 17. Multi-engine and instrument training. Track every hour against the table.
Month 18-20	Skill tests inside a six-month recency window. Licence application on eGCA. EPL generated on issue.
Month 20-24	Type rating decision - self-sponsored or bonded - timed to actual airline hiring. Apply to every carrier running a recruitment cycle.

The plan is deliberately front-loaded with cheap decisions and back-loaded with expensive ones. Every month you spend before the first big payment is a month in which you can still walk away with your savings intact.

35 Document checklist

Print this. Every item on it is something a school, a bank or DGCA will ask you for, usually at short notice.

- Class 10 marksheet and certificate
- Class 12 marksheet and certificate showing Physics and Mathematics, or NIOS marksheets for both subjects
- AIU equivalence certificate, if your schooling was under a foreign or international board
- Proof of date of birth, matching your Class 10 certificate exactly

- Proof of address
- Aadhaar and a valid passport
- Passport photographs in the DGCA-specified format, plus spare copies
- Class 2 medical certificate and, once issued, the Class 1 assessment
- CA-35 certificate from the medical examination centre, carried while the assessment is pending
- Computer Number allotment confirmation
- Pariksha registration and every exam admit card and result
- RTR(A) written and practical pass records, and the certificate once issued
- Pilot logbook, kept current and legible, with every endorsement signed
- Trainee agreement with the FTO, mutually signed, plus every payment receipt
- Block-wise fee schedule and the school's published refund policy
- Education loan sanction letter and disbursement records, if applicable
- Skill test reports and the licence application acknowledgement

36 FTO due-diligence scorecard

Score each school out of two on each line: 0 for no, 1 for a verbal yes, 2 for a written yes you can keep. Below 16 out of 24, keep looking.

1. DGCA approval is current, verified on DGCA's own site today
2. Current ranking category is known to me, and I have asked about it
3. I know how many aircraft are serviceable this week, not how many are registered
4. I know the current student-to-aircraft ratio
5. I have the realised average months-to-CPL for students who enrolled two years ago
6. The quoted fee itemises flying, ground school, simulator, landing and parking, examiner and accommodation
7. The flying fee is split into four 25 per cent blocks in the agreement
8. The refund policy is in writing and matches the October 2026 DGCA guidelines
9. There is no blanket non-refundable clause
10. The agreement states duration, aircraft types and hours in writing
11. The fleet includes, or gives access to, a multi-engine aircraft for the required hours
12. I have spoken to three students who finished in the last eighteen months

37 Budget worksheet

Fill the right-hand column with real quotes, not ranges. The total is the number your family actually needs to see.

Table 16. Worksheet - write your own figures in the last column

Line	Typical range	Your figure
Ground school and coaching	Rs 0.5 - 2 lakh	
DGCA exam fees (five papers, one attempt each)	Rs 12,500 regular	

Line	Typical range	Your figure
RTR(A) exam fees and coaching	Confirm on portal; add coaching	
Class 2 and Class 1 medicals, including renewals	Rs 0.1 - 0.35 lakh	
Flight training to 200 hours	Rs 30 - 64 lakh	
Multi-engine and instrument rating	Rs 3 - 8 lakh	
Books, uniform, headset, deposits, landing fees	Rs 0.7 - 3 lakh	
Living costs during training	Rs 2 - 6 lakh	
Extra hours and delay overrun	Rs 1 - 5 lakh	
Type rating and related courses	Rs 15 - 38 lakh	
Contingency at 10 per cent of the total	Calculated	

Two lines are almost always under-budgeted and both are on this sheet: extra hours, because weather and re-tests add them, and the type rating, because brochures leave it out. A budget that omits either is not a budget.

38 Forty questions, answered

Short answers, with the section that covers each one in full.

Can I become a pilot with a Commerce or Arts background?
Yes. You need Physics and Mathematics at 10+2 level, most commonly through NIOS, which DGCA and the airline cadet programmes accept. See section 6.

Is there a minimum percentage required by DGCA?
No. DGCA specifies a pass in 10+2 with Physics and Mathematics, not a percentage. Individual schools and cadet programmes set their own minimums - commonly 50, 51 or 60 per cent.

What is the minimum age?
18 on the date of application for a CPL. You can begin ground school and theory papers earlier, and many candidates are CPL-ready by 20 or 21.

Is there a maximum age?
DGCA states no upper age limit for registering as a flight crew candidate. Employers set their own limits - IndiGo's Junior First Officer criteria cap at 40, Air India's cadet programme at 30.

How long does it take?
Realistically two and a half to four years to a CPL, plus two to four months for a type rating, plus a variable wait for a first officer seat. Anyone quoting eighteen months as a firm number is quoting a best case.

How much does it cost?
Rs 55 lakh to Rs 1 crore all-in including the type rating, depending on the school tier and the aircraft. See section 3.

Can I do it without Physics and Maths?
Not under the current rules. Draft rules published in July 2025 propose removing that requirement, and as of October 2026 those rules had administrative approval but had not been published. Plan as though the requirement applies.

Do I need to be good at maths?
You need competent 10+2 mathematics, not competitive-exam mathematics. Air Navigation is the most numerical paper and it rewards practice rather than talent.

Can I wear glasses?
Yes. Corrected acuity must meet the standard and your refraction must fall within DGCA's limits. Plenty of airline pilots wear glasses.

Does colour blindness disqualify me?
Significant colour vision deficiency has historically been treated as disqualifying for a Class 1 in India, which is stricter than some other jurisdictions. Get assessed early - see section 9.

Is LASIK allowed?
Generally accepted subject to conditions including a post-operative waiting period, documented stability and pre-operative records. Keep your pre-surgery documentation.

What is a Computer Number?
A free, lifetime identifier issued by DGCA's Central Examination Organisation. You need it for every examination and for the licence. See section 11.

How many theory papers are there?
Five for a CPL: Air Regulations, Air Navigation, Aviation Meteorology, Technical General and Technical Specific. A performance paper applies only above 5,700 kg maximum take-off weight. RTR(A) is a separate examination. See section 12.

What is the pass mark?
70 per cent in each paper, with no negative marking.

How long is a passed paper valid?
Five years, which is why the whole set should be planned inside that window.

How much are the exam fees?
Rs 2,500 per paper in a regular session, Rs 5,000 in an on-demand session, plus Rs 500 per oral paper from the second attempt. Fees are non-refundable.

What is OLODE?
On-line-on-demand examination. It runs between the four regular sessions and costs exactly double per paper. Use it to fix a schedule problem, not as a default.

What is RTR(A)?
The Radio Telephone Operator (Restricted) certificate and licence for aeronautical use, mandatory for a CPL. DGCA has run the examination since 1 December 2025. See section 15.

Can I use an old WPC RTR?
Yes, if it was issued or renewed by WPC up to 15 July 2026. New services are through DGCA only.

What are the 200 hours?
Total flight time, of which 100 hours as pilot-in-command, 20 hours cross-country as PIC including a 300 nautical mile flight with full-stop landings at two aerodromes, 10 hours instrument and 5 hours night. See section 17.

Can simulator time count?
For the 10 hours of instrument time, no more than 5 hours may be on an approved simulator. Multi-engine time has its own limits - airlines typically cap simulator credit at 10 of the 25 hours.

What is an FTO?
A DGCA-approved Flying Training Organisation. There were 41 of them across 63 bases with over 400 aircraft by mid-2026.

How do I choose one?
Start with DGCA's ranking, published twice a year, then apply the nine questions in section 20 and the scorecard in section 36.

What does the ranking mean?
It grades schools by score: A+ at 85 per cent and above, A from 70, B from 50, C below 50. In April 2026, one of 35 ranked schools reached Category A.

What if my school shuts down mid-course?
Under DGCA's October 2026 guidelines you are ordinarily entitled to a refund of the entire unutilised fee where the cause is substantially attributable to the school, including suspension or cessation of its approval. Records must be released for transfer.

Can I be asked to pay the whole fee upfront?
No. The guidelines require flying fees to be paid in four progressive 25 per cent blocks, and the advance may never exceed the next block.

How long should a refund take?
Ordinarily within 15 working days after the required formalities, under the October 2026 guidelines.

Does DGCA help with a dispute with a foreign school?
No. DGCA has stated that refunds and contractual disputes with foreign schools are outside its purview.

Is training abroad better?
Not inherently. It adds visa, vetting and conversion dependencies. Of 1,331 CPLs issued in the first half of 2026, 791 came from Indian schools.

What is licence conversion?
Converting a foreign CPL to an Indian one: Air Regulation and a composite Navigation and Meteorology paper, skill tests in India on the type to be endorsed, an Indian Class 1 and verified original logbooks.

What is a type rating?
Training and certification on a specific airliner type, without which no airline can employ you to fly it. See section 26.

How much is a type rating?
Market estimates put an A320 rating at about Rs 15 to 30 lakh in India. No regulator publishes a rate card. Get an itemised written quote.

Should I self-fund a type rating or take a bonded programme?
If a structured programme with an employment letter is available and financeable, the bond usually converts an open market bet into a defined path. Self-fund only when a specific airline is actively hiring on that type.

What does a cadet programme cost?
Published partner figures range from about Rs 104 lakh to about USD 131,000 for CPL plus A320 type rating. Air India discloses cost to enrolled candidates before training.

Is a job guaranteed after a cadet programme?
No. Air India's own wording is that it will offer successful cadets employment subject to change as per the airline's pilot trajectory.

What do pilots earn?
Indicative 2026 monthly gross: Rs 1 to 2.7 lakh as a junior first officer, Rs 2.3 to 3.5 lakh as a first officer, and Rs 4.75 to 8.5 lakh as a captain. Take-home is materially lower. See section 29.

Will a bank lend me the money?
Yes - pilot training is an eligible course under public sector education loan schemes. SBI's ceiling for other courses is Rs 50 lakh; Bank of Baroda's aviation ceiling is Rs 125 lakh. Collateral applies above Rs 7.5 lakh. See section 31.

Can I get a loan without collateral?
Up to Rs 7.5 lakh at public sector banks with a parent as co-borrower. Above that, tangible collateral is generally required, though private lenders are more flexible at higher rates.

Is there a scholarship?
Not a national one for pilot training specifically. Some state governments run support schemes and some public sector flying clubs are subsidised, and the Indian Air Force route is free and paid - but it is a different career. Ask your chosen FTO what state schemes apply at its base.

What happens after I get the licence?
You apply to airlines running recruitment cycles, complete ground and simulator training, base training and about 100 hours of line training, then get released as a first officer. See section 30.

What if I am declared temporarily unfit?
Many findings are reviewable rather than permanent, with a defined window to treat and re-present. Work with the examiner and DGCA's medical assessor rather than around them.

39 Glossary

Term	Meaning
ATPL	Airline Transport Pilot Licence. The senior professional licence, required for command at most airlines.
ATR	An aircraft type, the ATR 72-600, used widely on Indian regional routes.
CAR	Civil Aviation Requirement. DGCA's regulatory instrument, cited by section and series.
Class 1 / Class 2	The two medical assessment standards. Class 1 is the commercial standard.
Computer Number	DGCA's unique lifetime identifier for a flight crew candidate.
CPL	Commercial Pilot Licence. The licence that allows you to be paid to fly.
DGCA	Directorate General of Civil Aviation, India's civil aviation regulator.
ELP	English Language Proficiency, assessed to ICAO levels and endorsed on the licence.
EPL	Electronic Personnel Licence. India's digital pilot licence, displayed through the eGCA app.
eGCA	DGCA's licensing platform and mobile app.
FRTOL	Flight Radio Telephone Operator's Licence.
FTO	Flying Training Organisation, approved by DGCA to conduct flying training.
IR	Instrument Rating. Permission to fly in instrument meteorological conditions.
ME	Multi-Engine. An endorsement allowing flight on aircraft with more than one engine.
MCC	Multi-Crew Coordination. A course on operating as part of a two-pilot crew.
OLODE	On-Line-On-Demand Examination. DGCA's on-demand exam sessions, priced at double the regular fee.
PIC	Pilot-in-Command. The pilot responsible for the flight.
Pariksha	DGCA's examination portal, pariksha.dgca.gov.in.
SPL	Student Pilot Licence. The training-stage authorisation.
RTR(A)	Radio Telephone Operator (Restricted) certificate and licence, aeronautical. Run by DGCA since 1 December 2025.
Type rating	Certification on a specific airliner type, endorsed on your licence.

40 Official sources, and how to re-verify

Every regulatory fact in this guide was taken from a primary source in October 2026. Rules change. Here is where to check each one yourself.

- Aircraft Rules, 1937, Schedule II Section J - CPL eligibility, the 200 hours and the skill tests. On dgca.gov.in under Rules and Regulations.
- CAR Section 7 Series B Part I - the theory paper list and examination eligibility. On dgca.gov.in under Civil Aviation Requirements.
- CAR Section 7 Series C Part I - medical requirements, centres and validity.
- CAR Section 7 Series D Part I - FTO requirements, including the instructor, aircraft and student ratio.
- CAR Section 7 Series G Part VI, dated 27 November 2025 - the RTR examination, syllabus and pass marks.
- CAR Section 7 Series G Part I - conversion of a foreign licence.
- Flying Training Circular 02 of 2026, dated 5 October 2026 - FTO and trainee agreements, fee blocks, refunds and transfer.
- DGCA FTO ranking, April 2026 - the category table, published on dgca.gov.in and by the Ministry of Civil Aviation through PIB.
- DGCA Programme of Examinations 2026 and the Pariksha notice board - session dates, application windows and fees.
- DGCA Flight Crew Licensing Circular 01 of 2024, as revised - the Electronic Personnel Licence.
- Rajya Sabha Starred Question No. 25, answered 2 February 2026, and the Lok Sabha reply of February 2026 - CPL numbers, pilot counts and FTO capacity.
- PIB releases of 20 February 2025 and 21 January 2026 - the launch of EPL for CPL and for ATPL.
- Air India Cadet Pilot Programme pages on cadetpilot.airindia.com, and IndiGo's flight operations careers pages and 'Becoming a Pilot' guide.
- Indira Gandhi Rashtriya Uran Akademi's published 2026 entrance advertisement - fees, seats and eligibility.
- SBI Student Loan Scheme and Bank of Baroda Baroda Gyan scheme pages - ceilings, collateral, margin and moratorium.
- The Bharatiya Vayuyan Adhiniyam, 2024 on India Code, and the draft Bharatiya Vayuyan Niyam, 2025 published by the Ministry of Civil Aviation.

One habit is worth more than any of it: before you pay anyone, open dgca.gov.in and check the two things that change most often - the FTO's current approval status, and the current examination session. A five-minute check has saved candidates more money than any guide can.

> *This playbook is educational material. It is not legal, financial or career advice for your specific circumstances, and it is not a substitute for DGCA's published regulations, your medical examiner's assessment, or your lender's sanction terms. Verify every figure that matters to you at the source before you commit money.*